
Youtube Music:

Critique of Mobile Information Architecture and Navigation

Report: November 2023 a

Introduction:

YouTube Music, introduced by Google in 2015, is a music streaming application. Integrated with YouTube and other Google services such as Google Assistant smart speakers, it provides easy access to songs and their official music videos.

Membership options include free and premium, with the latter removing ads & allowing background playback.

App Logo: The logo consists of a red rounded rectangle with a white play button icon inside, followed by the word "Music" in a bold, black, sans-serif font.

(Wikimedia Foundation, 2023)

Audience:

The audience for this app are people who like listening to music, and studies show that people prefer to use streaming apps for listening to music on mobile.

(Zantal-Wiener, 2022)

The Primary Navigation Menu of the app

In some Android smartphones, YouTube Music comes pre-installed. Nevertheless, it is available for download on the app store. If you already have your Google Account logged in, it should automatically log you into the app.

Due to integrations with YouTube and Google, it provides recommendations even if the user is opening the app for the first time.

Post-installation, your landing page might look similar to Fig.1a. However, if offline, the landing page is the Library (Fig.1d).

There are four main screens: Home, Samples, Explore and Library.

Home (Fig.1) contains a list of songs, albums and playlists based on the user's listening history.

The Samples page (see Fig.1b) contains snippets of songs that can be used for creating YouTube Shorts.

The Explore page (see Fig.1c) is a more comprehensive area for finding songs through broader categories such as New Releases or Moods and Genres.

The Library page (see Fig.1d) contains the songs, albums and playlists that the user has liked.

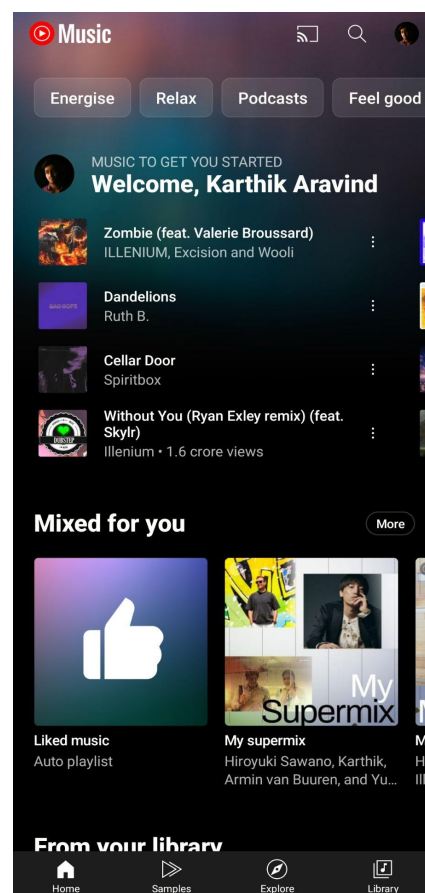


Fig. 1a Home

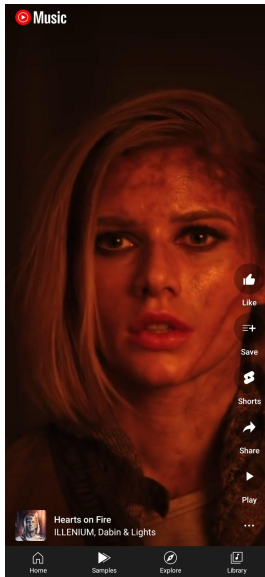


Fig 1b Samples

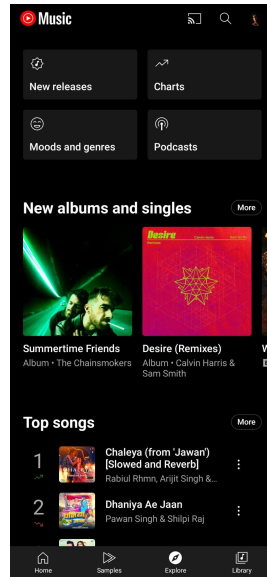


Fig 1c Explore

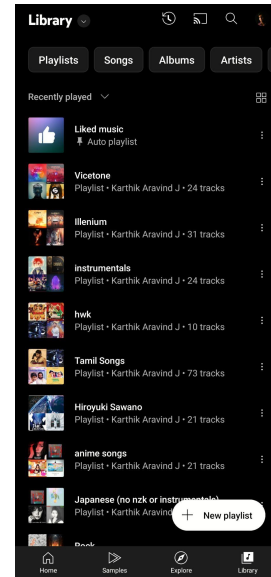


Fig 1d Library

Navigating the App

Fig. 1a revealed a bottom app bar with four labels: Home, Samples, Explore, and Library. Active tab icons have a white fill, while others have a white outline.

The fourth tab ('Feel good') seems to exist beyond the screen's confines, but can also be misconstrued as a formatting issue. It is, in fact, indicating hidden labels (see Fig. 4a).

It includes a top app bar with a logo (L) and icons (R) for Cast, Search, and a Display photo, their screens which are shown in Fig. 2 respectively.

1. The Cast icon reveals a hovering box displaying available displays for casting.
2. The Search icon opens a drawer with a search bar, a back button, and a voice search option (Microphone icon).
3. The Account drawer, though not labelled as such, is accessed by pressing the Display Photo.

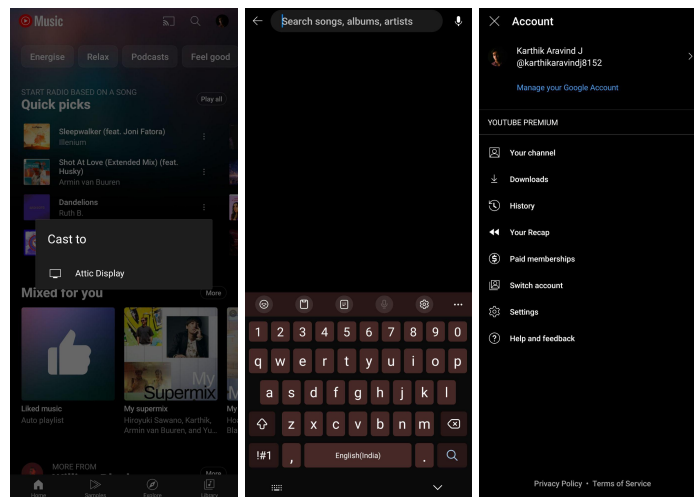


Fig. 2 Icons on the top when pressed (in Order - Cast, Search, Account)

The top app bar vanishes on vertical scroll (see Fig. 3a). Fig. 3b shows a modified header for the Library page.

Fig. 3c reveals "Cast to" and "Search" icons are reused in headers across Artist, Album, and Playlist pages, which have a Back icon in the logo's place.

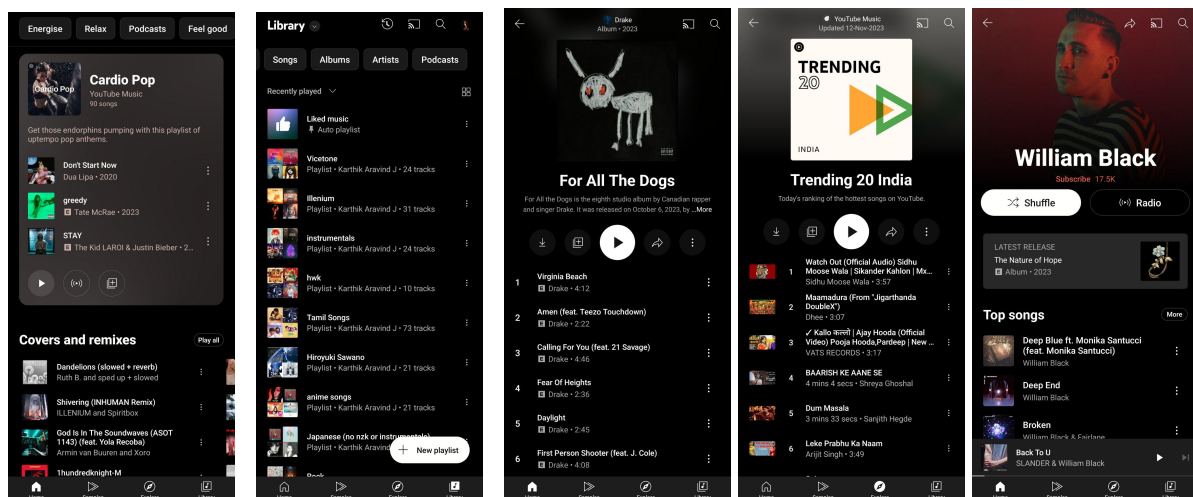


Fig. 3a Vertical Scroll Fig 3b Library Page

Fig 3c Modified Header in pages for
(L to R) Album, Playlist and Artist

The tabs section is scrollable as can be seen in Fig. 4a. When a tab is selected, the screen is repopulated. Horizontal scrolling is used for tabs, evident from partially visible content to the right (see Fig. 4b), which is consistent across the app's sub-sections (songs, albums and playlists)

*All images used for the purpose of this critique have 'Dark' mode enabled on the app.

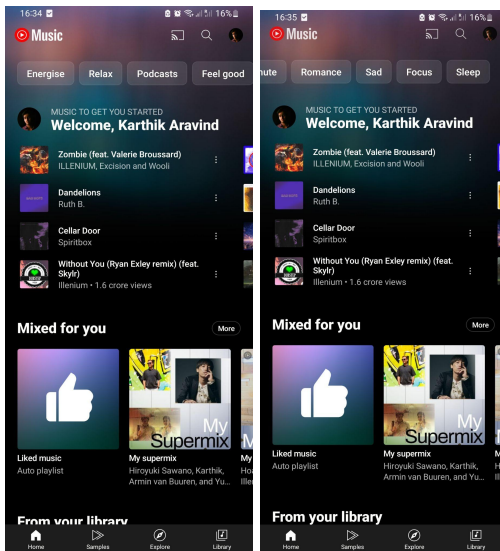


Fig. 4a Tabs Section

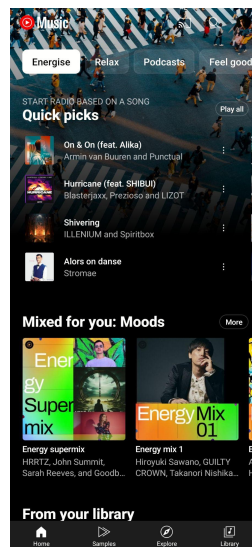


Fig. 4b tab selected

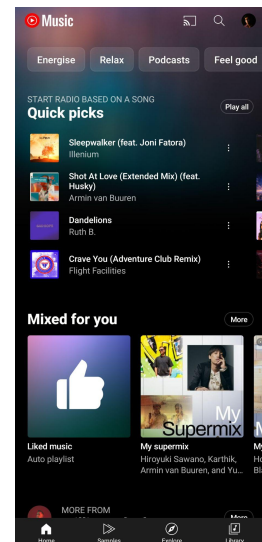


Fig. 4c Reverting Tab Selection

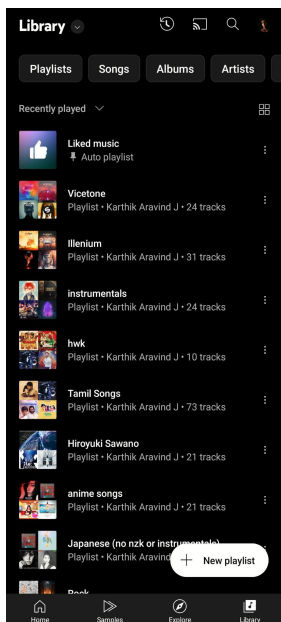


Fig. 5a Library Section - pop up menu

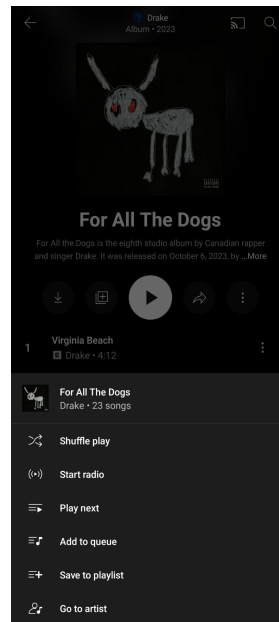
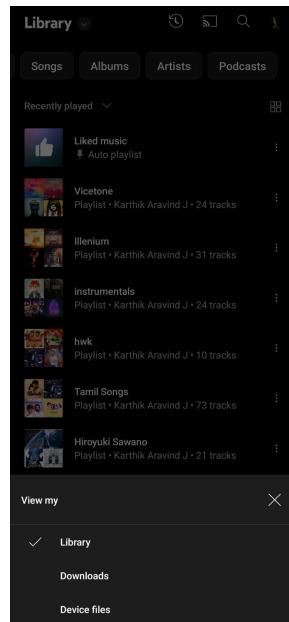
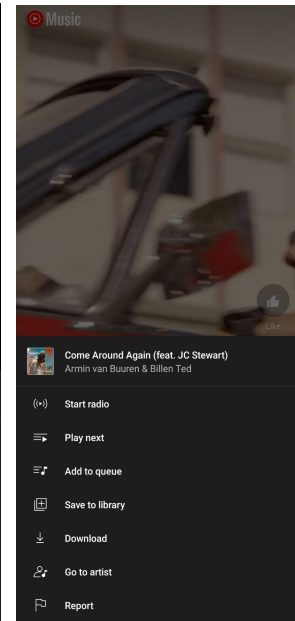


Fig 5b dynamic pop up menus



The Top app bar in the Library page also contains the functionality to view the user's device audio files (Device Files) & YouTube Music downloads (Downloads) accessible through a down arrow button on the Top app bar, but it pops up from the bottom of the screen (see Fig.5a). Similarly (see Fig.5b), the pop up menus also pop up from the bottom of the screen.

*All images used for the purpose of this critique have 'Dark' mode enabled on the app.

Fig 6a depicts the playback window where we can see the song's basic information and which we can visually split into 4 sections (top to bottom) -

1. Top tabs section - Song and Video
2. A display window (album cover/music video)
3. Playback features (Shuffle, Rewind, Pause/Play, etc); and
4. Bottom tabs section - Up Next, Lyrics and Related (pushes upward for Fig. 6b, 6c, 6d respectively).

Through the sub-sections inside 'Related' in Fig 6d, the user can navigate away from the playback window directly into the artist's page, related songs, albums, and playlist pages.

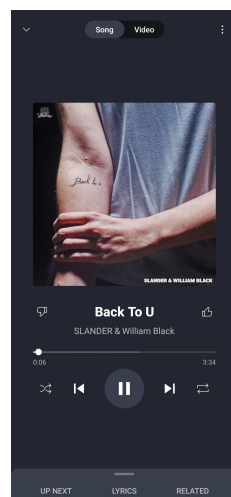


Fig. 6a Playback window,

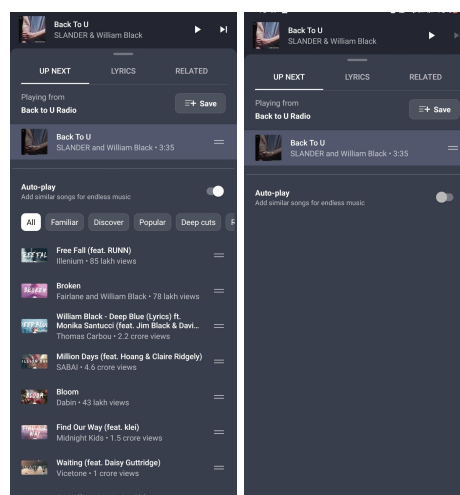


Fig 6b Playback tab Up Next

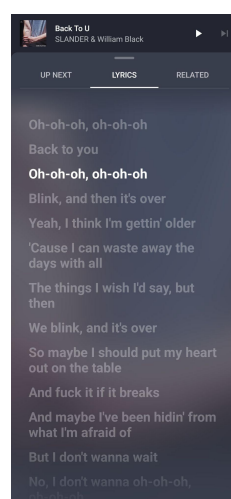


Fig. 6c Playback window Lyrics

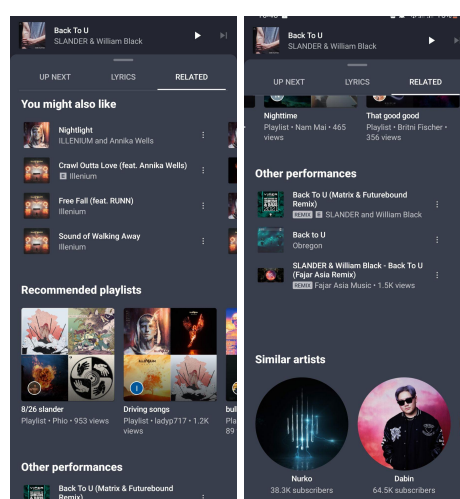


Fig 6d Playback tab Related

Strengths:

1. The bottom pop up menus are handy as users can access items in a bottom pop up menu without having to change their grip. (Arun H., 2021)
2. In offline mode, the app defaults to the Library page upon opening, ensuring users can access their saved content - a practice followed by rivals like Spotify. (Cherednichenko, 2023)
3. The icons on the bottom app bar have label names and icons which complement each other, providing redundancy, leading to better usability and accessibility. (Johnson, 2023).
4. The top app bar is hidden when scrolling vertically downwards. As a result, the user can view more content. The tabs section is stuck to the top while scrolling, as it can be used to repopulate the content on the fly without having to scroll to the top. Since the menu required for navigation is in the bottom, the top app bar can be concealed while scrolling. (Berry, 2021)
5. The app's interface mostly uses icons for action buttons, with the exception of the bottom app bar, which uses both label names and icons. They effectively achieve the purposes of performing an action and navigation respectively. (Johnson, 2023)
6. Horizontal scrolling is preferred for mobile (Shakir, 2018). The horizontal scroll in the songs, albums, and playlists sections is effective because it is highlighted by the partially viewable items.

Weaknesses (and suggestions):

1. Questionable visual indication: For horizontal scrolling feature in the tabs section. Can adjust the space between the tabs to have the 'Feel Good' tab outside of the screen (at least 40% of the tab) or make the tabs smaller and include the fifth tab partially inside the screen. (See Fig.4a)
2. Inconsistent top app bar: Only two icons (Search and Cast to) are reused. It makes sense to not have the Account section and Logo in every page but there is a Share icon present in the Artist screen which is not present in the top app bar of the Album or Playlist pages. (See Fig.3c)

3. Reverting tab selection: On the Home page, selecting a Tab results in content repopulation (see Fig.4b) and in the absence of a back button, pressing the active tab returns the user to the previous screen (see Fig.4c). However, this is not the same Home page screen the user viewed before tab selection (see Fig.4a). This can be corrected so as to not confuse the viewer as to which page they were at as it might help the user access a song/album/playlist they saw on their screen prior to selecting a tab.
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References:

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